Faithful Finances

Week 4: The Spender

Matthew 6:21 (ESV)

For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.

The Bag with Holes

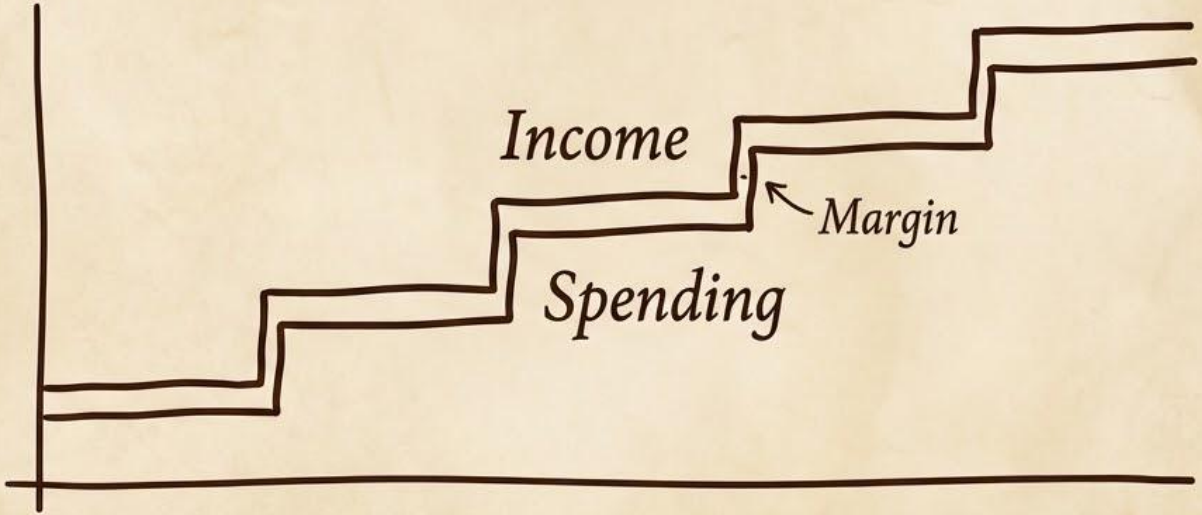
"Consider your ways. You have sown much, and harvested little. You eat, but you never have enough; you drink, but you never have your fill. You clothe yourselves, but no one is warm. And he who earns wages does so to put them into a bag with holes."
(Haggai 1:5-6 ESV)

The Cultural Default

- 67% live paycheck to paycheck.
- 56% cannot cover a $1,000 emergency.
- Avg. Car Payment: $748/month.
- Housing: High Prices + High Taxes = The Squeeze.

Lifestyle Creep

When income rises, spending rises to match it.



The Trap: Margin Stagnation.

The Root of Spending

"For all that is in the world—the desires of the flesh and the desires of the eyes and pride of life—is not from the Father but is from the world." (1 John 2:16 ESV)

1. Lust of the Flesh (Impulse)
2. Lust of the Eyes (Envy)
3. Pride of Life (Status)

Warning Lights

- **Anxiety:** Does spending keep you awake?
- **Underwater:** Do you owe more than you own?
- **Credit Cards:** Are you carrying a balance?
- **Car Test:** Can you pay it off in 3 years?

Defining Margin

Income > Expenses = Freedom

Margin is the gap between your Income and your Expenses.

Margin Illustration

Wisdom in Spending

Consuming

Eating the seed (Liability).

Multiplying

Planting the seed (Asset/Tool).

Fun is Not a Sin

"God 'richly provides us with everything to enjoy.' (1 Timothy 6:17)

Rule: Don't eat your seed corn.

The Leaks

- The Convenience Tax (Dining/Coffee)
- The Subscription Bleed
- The Kid/Peer Flation
- Cars (Depreciation Engines)
- Housing (The Patience Game)

Three Levels of Discipline

3. Contentment

2. Self-Control

1. Avoidance

The Budget

It is a Permission Slip, not a punishment.

Telling your money where to go instead of wondering where it went.

The Anatomy

Tier 1: Priority (Giving & Saving).
Tier 2: Needs (Four Walls).
Tier 3: Wants (Lifestyle).

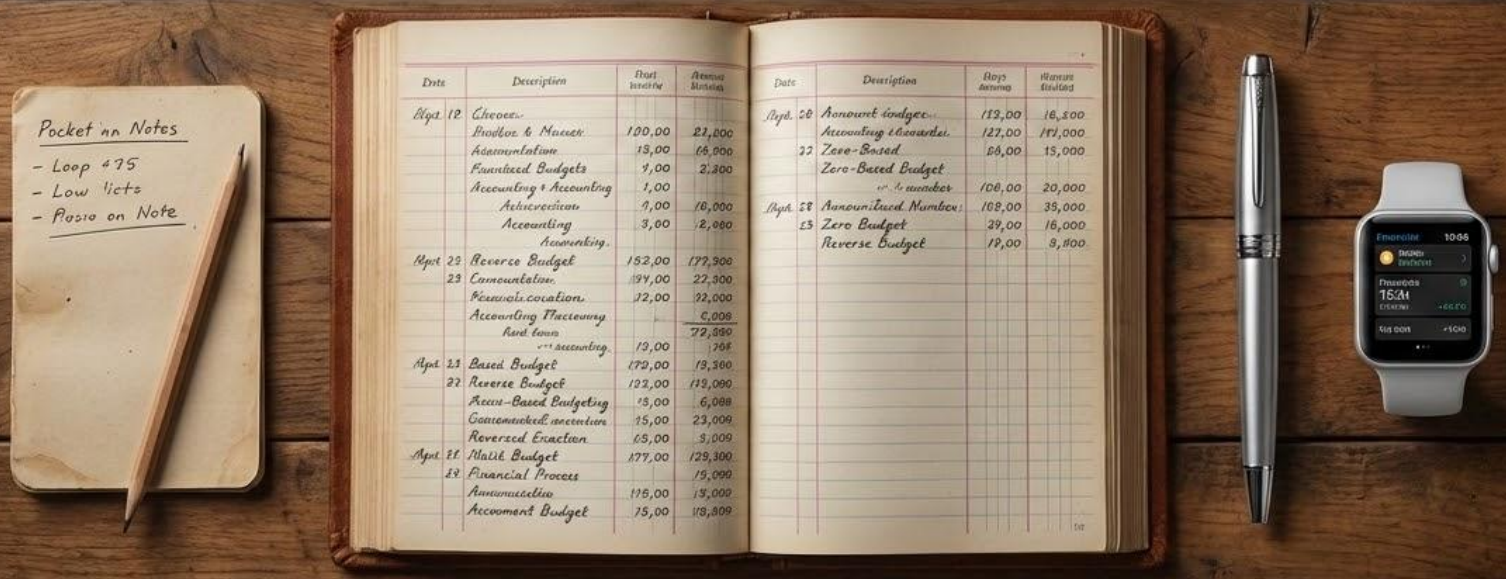
The Challenge

Fixed Expenses: Predictable (Rent, Netflix).
Variable Expenses: Changing (Groceries, Gas).

Budgeting is a skill, not a math test. Don’t quit.

Choose Your Method

- Level 1: The “One Number” Strategy (Simple).
- Level 2: Zero-Based Budgeting (The Gold Standard).
- Level 3: The Reverse Budget (For the Graduate).



Zero-Based Budget

JAN FEB MAR APR MAY JUN JULY AUG SEPT OCT NOV DEC

Total Income	Anticipated	Actual
Salary 1	$2,500.00	$2,500.00
Salary 2	$3,200.00	$3,000.00
Social Security/Pension	$500.00	$500.00
Interest/Dividends	$470.00	$450.00
Other Income	$300.00	$300.00
Other Income	$130.00	$120.00
Total	$7,100.00	$6,870.00

Off the Top	Anticipated	Actual
Monthly Savings	$700.00	$550.00
Tax Witholding	$2,000.00	$2,000.00
Emergency Fund	$400.00	$450.00
Retirement Fund	$500.00	$420.00
Other		
Other		
Subtotal	$3,600.00	$3,420.00
Budget Remaining	$3,500.00	$3,450.00

Bills	Anticipated	Actual
Rent/Mortgage	$800.00	$800.00
Electricity	$90.00	$90.00
Gas	$50.00	$50.00
Water	$30.00	$30.00
Trash	$50.00	$50.00
Television	$65.00	$65.00
Internet	$60.00	$60.00
Health Insurance	$70.00	$70.00
Car Insurance	$75.00	$75.00
Home Insurance		
Pet Insurance		
Other		
Other		
Other		
Subtotal	$1,290.00	$1,290.00
Budget Remaining	$2,210.00	$2,160.00

Spending	Anticipated	Actual
Groceries	$400.00	$360.00
Gas/Transportation	$80.00	$100.00
Home & Cleaning Supplies	$100.00	$100.00
Personal Hygiene	$100.00	$20.00
Clothing	$150.00	$150.00
Pet Supplies	$100.00	$50.00
Books, Magazines & Media	$130.00	$80.00
Restaurants & Delivery	$210.00	$240.00
Other		
Other		
Other		
Other		
Subtotal	$1,270.00	$1,100.00
Budget Remaining	$940.00	$1,060.00

Debt	Minimum	Amount
Credit Card 1	$80.00	$100.00
Credit Card 2	$120.00	$160.00
Student Loan	$240.00	$300.00
Medical Debt	$500.00	$500.00
Other		
Other		
Other		
Other		
Subtotal	$940.00	$1,060.00
Budget Remaining	$0.00	$0.00

Total Expenses	Anticipated	Actual
Total Income	$7,100.00	$6,870.00
Total Off the Top	$3,600.00	$3,420.00
Total Bills	$1,290.00	$1,290.00
Total Spending	$1,270.00	$1,100.00
Total Debt	$940.00	$1,060.00
Subtotal –	$7,100.00	$6,870.00
Final Budget (should = $0)	$0.00	$0.00

- EveryDollar
- YNAB
- Spreadsheet

Budgeting in Marriage

One Team. One Book. No Secrets.

- The Nerd: Prepares.
- The Free Spirit: Partners.

Flying Solo

Accountability & Boundaries

You need a ‘Money Mentor’ to check your drift.

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Discussion

- Where have you upgraded to ‘Best’ when ‘Good Enough’ was fine?
- What is the definition of Contentment?
- Is ‘Future Garbage’ worth the hours you worked?

Summary

- **Margin = Freedom**
- **Budget = Permission**
- **Contentment = The Cure**

Next Steps

- **The Spending Plan:** Create a Zero-Based Budget.
- **The Audit:** Cancel one subscription.

Loan Scenario Spreadsheet